

Practice Questions: Language and Thought

Section A: Multiple Choice Questions

1. The Whorf Hypothesis, in its strongest form, claims that:
A) Language reflects culture but doesn't affect thought
B) Language determines thought completely
C) Language and thought are unrelated
D) Only written language affects thought
2. The 'Euphemism Treadmill' refers to the process where:
A) New words are created faster than old ones disappear
B) Polite terms eventually gain negative connotations and get replaced
C) Political language becomes more formal over time
D) Slang words become part of descriptive grammar
3. Chomsky's Universal Grammar theory suggests that:
A) All languages have identical grammar rules
B) Humans are born with an innate capacity for language
C) Grammar must be taught in school to be learned
D) Sign language is not a true language
4. Linguistic Competence refers to:
A) The mistakes you make when speaking
B) Your unconscious knowledge of language rules
C) The formal grammar taught in textbooks
D) How fast you can learn a second language
5. Studies of chimpanzees learning sign language showed that they:
A) Developed full grammar and created new sentences
B) Could learn words but lacked complex syntax and creativity
C) Taught sign language to their offspring
D) Performed better than human children at language tasks

Section B: Short Answer Questions

1. Explain the difference between descriptive grammar and prescriptive grammar. Give one example of each.
2. Why is American Sign Language considered evidence that language doesn't have to be spoken?
3. Give an example of how word choice can shape political opinion. Explain why it works.
4. What is the difference between linguistic competence and linguistic performance? Which one is affected when you're tired and make speech errors?

5. Summarize the 'weak version' of the Whorf Hypothesis that linguists accept today.

Answer Key

Section A: Multiple Choice

1. B - The strong version says language determines thought completely. The weak version, which is accepted, says it only influences it.
2. B - Polite terms become negative over time and get replaced, like 'crippled' → 'handicapped' → 'disabled'.
3. B - Chomsky argued we have innate brain structures that make language acquisition possible.
4. B - Competence is your unconscious knowledge. Performance is what you actually say.
5. B - Chimps learned vocabulary but didn't develop grammar or creative language use.

Section B: Short Answer - Sample Answers

1. **Descriptive grammar** describes how people actually speak, e.g., people say 'wanna' and 'want to'. **Prescriptive grammar** tells you how you 'should' speak, e.g., 'Don't end sentences with prepositions.'
2. ASL has its own grammar, syntax, and can express abstract ideas. Children acquire it naturally. This shows language is a cognitive system, not tied to sound.
3. Example: 'Estate tax' vs 'death tax'. The second phrase triggers negative emotion and frames the tax as unfair, which shapes opinion before people analyze the policy.
4. **Competence** is your mental knowledge of language. **Performance** is actual speech. Performance is affected when you're tired and make errors.
5. The weak version says language influences attention, memory, and categorization, but doesn't rigidly determine all thought. It's like tinted glasses, not a prison.